

CHOICE OF FINESSES

South opens 1NT (15-17 balanced), North raises to 3NT, South declares.

West leads a heart.

Teaching feature: declarer has ONE heart stopper (the Ace) and TWO finesses available, in spades and clubs. WEST — the opening leader — has a 5-card heart suit headed by KQ. After holding up the Ace to exhaust EAST of hearts, the choice of finesse decides the contract:

- Clubs — Axx in South, KJx in North. Lead small from South toward dummy's KJ. If it loses, EAST wins — and East has no hearts left. ← SAFE.
- Spades — KJx in South, Axx in North. Lead small from dummy toward South's KJ. If it loses, WEST wins — and West cashes the long hearts. ← FATAL.

The decision:

- Duck hearts until East is out (West leads them; East has only 2-3).
- Then take the CLUB finesse — it loses safely to East.
- Do NOT take the SPADE finesse — it hands the lead to West, the danger hand, who cashes the established hearts.

West has the long suit but no outside entry, so the only way West regains the lead is if you give it to them with the spade finesse. Don't.

Reference: <https://www.bridgebum.com/avoidance.php>